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Imperatives in voice-overs in British TV commercials: 'Get this, buy that, taste the other'

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Abstract

Television commercials are often thought of as bothersome multimedia artefacts that by their very existence spoil our viewing pleasure at regular intervals. Not only that, but they seem to have the habit of ordering us around. This aspect of TV ads has often been commented on by experts and laypersons alike. Therefore, we decided to tackle this issue and look at the prototypical expression of directives, that is, imperatives in voice-overs in television commercials. To this end we have carried out an empirical analysis of imperatives in voice-overs in the MATVA corpus (Multimodal Analysis of TV Ads) which contains transcriptions of nearly 800 voice-overs in British TV ads recorded on six days during 2009, 2010 and 2011. We provide an exhaustive quantitative and qualitative profile of imperatives in contemporary TV advertising. This includes information on the distribution of imperatives, the most common verbs in imperative clauses, and their discourse function. We are also able to show conclusively that the directive force of imperatives in TV ads is more akin to advice or recommendation than commands, and explain from a discourse-pragmatic perspective why this is so.

Keywords

Advertising, corpus analysis, directives, discourse, engagement, imperatives, persuasion, pragmatics, television

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Introduction

There are several reasons why the analysis of TV ads is a worthwhile task for researchers. Probably the most compelling one is that every day millions of people are exposed to them. It is difficult to gauge how much influence TV commercials have on viewers. However, taking into account the enormous amounts of money spent on them – more than any other type of advertising to date[1] – it seems logical to assume that they do shape our buying habits to a certain extent. Several researchers posit that TV ads do not only influence what we buy. According to Williamson (1978: 10–11), Coltrane and Adams (1997: 326) and Fairclough (2001: 36), they embody largely conservative views of society which influence how we view society as a whole. It is therefore essential to analyse in detail how this is achieved.

TV ads can be described as purveyors of information whose primary goal is to persuade viewers to acquire commodities or services (Martínez-Camino and Pérez-Saiz, 2012: 455). Lakoff (1982: 28) defines 'persuasion' as 'the attempt or intention of one participant to change the behavior, feelings, intentions or viewpoint of another by communicative means'. TV advertising is a core member of the persuasive genres along with political and religious propaganda (see Schmidt and Kess, 1986: 91–94). In genres of this type the addresser exerts total control regarding the messages emitted. For this reason, Lakoff (1982) refers to addressees in advertising as the *audiencehood*, since, in contrast with ordinary conversation, TV viewers are a mass of passive recipients without an active role in shaping the interaction. Paradoxically, advertisers cannot be certain that viewers will pay attention to their ads or even watch them at all. Katz (2010: 122) points out that one can only estimate exposure to the media and not to an ad itself. In other words, a viewer may be drowsy and hardly be aware of an ad, deliberately ignore it, or use a DVR to skip to the next programme, etc. Only the repetition of the same ad during an advertising campaign, and the appeal of multimedia paraphernalia, may minimize some of these drawbacks. However, there are even more powerful reasons why ads may not achieve their purpose. Even though a viewer may watch an ad with great interest, he or she may be unable or unwilling to be persuaded to acquire the advertised commodity. For example, a low-income viewer may watch a luxury car advertisement but be unable to acquire the car due to its price. Also, if a viewer has recently purchased a washing machine, he/she is unlikely to be willing to buy another one, no matter how compelling the ad may be. Taking these factors into account, it is the advertiser who is apparently disadvantaged from a power perspective. This has implications with regard to advertising discourse – including imperatives – vis-a-vis politeness.

Within TV ads, voice-overs (VOs), that is, voices which are 'not visible nor synchronously anchored in a depicted speaking person' (Stigel, 2001: 336) are especially salient. Leech (1966: 39) describes them as '[t]he most important linguistic means of conveying the advertising message on television'. Thus, many researchers (Downs and Harrison, 1985: 17; Piller, 2006: 159; Wee et al., 1995: 50) call VOs 'the voice of authority'. Following Goffman (1981: 144–145), a VO is a conglomerate of different voices. The actual voice we hear is that of an 'animator', that is, an actor or actress hired to read a previously written script; the 'author' may be made up of the contributions of copywriters, media salespersons, executives and lawyers, while the 'principal' is the person or

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entity 'who is committed to what the words say' (Stern, 1994: 9) which, in the case of TV ads, would be the firm being advertised.

Even though images and music have been used since the very beginning of TV advertising, viewers often remember the slogans in VOs long after they have forgotten the storyline or the images of this or that ad. A few examples should suffice to convince those who are acquainted with recent British TV ads that this is true: *Take a break, take a Kit-Kat* (Kit-Kat), *You're worth it* (L'Oréal), *I'm lovin' it* (MacDonald's).

In the following sections we will centre our attention on imperatives in VOs in television commercials as a look at their frequency and function can supply us with useful information about the nature of the discourse of TV ads.

Imperatives as directives

Our decision to focus on imperatives rather than other elements in VOs was sparked by the predominant view in the literature that they are an important part of advertising copy (Barron, 2012: 271; Byrne, 1992: 66; Myers, 1994: 47; Ren, 2011: 744). Concomitant with this view is Leech's (1966: 30) remark that consumers are under the impression of 'forever being *told* to *get* this, *buy* that, *taste* the other' (our emphasis). Imperatives belong to the wider category of directives, that is, communicative acts whose goal is to get people to carry out 'such acts as requests, prohibitions and instructions, as well as orders and commands' (Downing and Locke, 2006: 177). Imperatives are the core or unmarked members of the directive speech act category in much the same way that statements are prototypically associated with declaratives and questions with interrogatives. Nevertheless, they are not the only clause types that instantiate this speech act. Downing and Locke (2006: 208) underline that polite directives can also be expressed through modalized interrogatives: 'Will/could/would/can't you open the book?'; or deontic modals as in: 'Dogs must be kept on a lead.' Hyland, in his research into academic genres (2002: 237), shows how directives can also be signalled by predicative adjectives, for example, in phrase frames of the type *it is * to*, where the gap can be filled by adjectives like 'critical, 'crucial', 'essential', 'important', 'indispensable' or 'vital' (see discussion of phrase frames in Fuster-Márquez, 2014). However, early on in our analysis, we found that the presence of other directives is negligible in the discourse of TV advertising, which is one of the reasons we centred on the much more frequent use of imperatives,

Regarding the function of imperatives, Downing and Locke (2006: 177) warn readers against associating them too narrowly with commands. In fact, they point out that commands are only found 'in contexts of great inequality and power such as the military' (see also Biber et al., 1999: 220; Huddleston, 2002: 929–930; Quirk et al., 1985: 831–832; Takahashi, 2011: 5). In ordinary usage, imperatives actually cover a wide range of illocutionary acts, including prohibitions, requests, pleas, advice, recommendations, warnings, suggestions, etc. From a politeness perspective, Brown and Levinson (1987 [1978]: 69) classify imperatives as essentially bald on-record expressions which can potentially threaten the hearer's face, but caution that this is not, by any means, always the case. They acknowledge that there are factors that override or circumvent possible face threats, such as when imperatives are used to warn someone of danger (p. 72), or when they benefit the hearer and, consequently, 'do not require great sacrifices' (p. 69). Also,

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imperatives can also be used to avoid the 'imposition of prolixity and obscurity' (Blum-Kulka, 1987: 145; Brown and Levinson, 1987 [1978]: 131).

In his study of academic writing, Hyland (2002: 215) rightly observes that if imperatives were so face-threatening and actually breached the 'cordial community contract' that exists between writers and readers, they would not be found in scholarly texts at all. This logic can be extended to other discourse types. To a great extent, whether imperatives are perceived as face-threatening or not depends on the addressee's expectations in different communicative situations (Martínez-Camino and Pérez-Saiz, 2012: 454). Pérez-Hernández and Ruiz de Mendoza (2002: 263) use the term 'optionality' to refer to the degree of freedom addressees have to comply with the directive issued by the imperative. They argue that optionality is low when the addressee has no real alternative but to comply with the speaker's wishes or request. Low optionality is illustrated by examples such as 'Keep off the grass', where 'failure to comply is not countenanced – or is liable to provoke sanctions' (Huddleston, 2002: 929). High optionality exists when the addressee has no real obligation to comply with the directive. Such is the case regarding imperatives in VOs. Given this situation, our hypothesis is that imperatives in VOs are carefully chosen to express advice or recommendations as they are directives that benefit the addressee rather than the addresser (see Huddleston, 2002: 930). In consequence, imperatives in VOs are not face-threatening because they are couched as being for the benefit of the viewer and are nearer the high optionality pole regarding obligation. In the following sections we will see whether this is borne out through the analysis of our corpus.

Voice-overs in the MATVA corpus: Technical and methodological issues

In this section we will describe our corpus of British TV ads and the sub-corpus of VOs within it. The MATVA corpus was recorded from the British television channels ITV and Channel 4 in March and June 2009, September 2010 and November 2011. Table 1 provides the details of the dates and times of recordings.

MATVA can be regarded as a fairly representative sample of recent TV advertising broadcast on British television. To our knowledge, with a total of 2140 ads, MATVA is larger than other corpora of its kind described in the literature to date. It is certainly larger than the corpora exploited for studies on imperatives in VOs. For their contrastive

Table 1. Dates and times of recording (MATVA).

Date	Time
19/03/2009	8.00–19.00
20/03/2009	8.00–19.00
24/06/2009	8.00–19.00
24/06/2009	8.00–19.00
10/09/2010	8.00–20.00
20/11/2011	8.00–24.00

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Table 2. TV ads in our corpus before and after filtering.

Total number of ads	2140
Non-duplicated	1122
Ads with VOs	932
Ads with non-duplicated VOs	785

analysis, Schmidt et al. (1995: 292) report having examined 50 TV ads from four countries (the US, Japan, China and Korea), while O'Neill and Casanovas-Catalá's analysis (1997: 265) was based on a corpus of 50 ads recorded from TV3 in Catalonia, and the British Sky News channel. Ohata's (2004: 202) corpus of Japanese and American ads consists of eight hours of recordings in each language, but the analysis is based on a sample of 120 ads.

There is no agreement in the literature about the features of a reliable corpus sample of TV ads. Ads are normally selected, for instance, according to pre-established typologies, time slots or the interest of specific channels. Some very general distinctions among ads, such as commercial versus non-commercial, are widely accepted. Most research has focused on the commercial type, a tradition that started with Leech (1966: 25). In much of the research reported, primetime commercials broadcast during breaks on major channels are the preferred choices. Schmidt et al. (1995: 292–293) acknowledge that their samples might have yielded different results if their analysis had included TV ads broadcast at different times of the day or over weekends, or if, instead of examining nationally distributed commercials, they had included samples of local channels. In order to obtain a representative corpus of British TV advertising and to overcome some of the shortcomings reported in the literature, we decided to examine both commercial and non-commercial ads even though the latter make up only 6% of all the ads in MATVA. Our corpus also includes both national and regional ads – the latter making up a negligible percentage of the total.

Regarding size, compared to written corpora, TV ad corpora are understandably smaller due to the time-consuming and labour-intensive transcription process. Nevertheless, Bowker (2001: 351), Flowerdew (2005: 329) and Gledhill (1996: 5) show that smaller corpora, as is the case with MATVA, are reliable when dealing with domain-specific languages. Having said this, representativeness cannot be solely based on the number of tokens. For this type of research, it is of paramount importance to access a sufficiently large number of different texts. Our corpus of analysis satisfies this requirement as it is made up of 785 VO texts which have been pruned from a total of 2140 recorded ads (see Table 2). The manual filtering process was necessary in the first place to eliminate duplicate ads. Anyone who watches commercial TV stations is aware that the same ad may be aired several times a day. One particularly extreme case in MATVA is the Sky+Box commercial, which was shown no fewer than 29 times on one day. After weeding out these duplicate ads, we were left with 1122 distinct ads.

In order to obtain our sub-corpora of VOs we eliminated ads with no VOs. This left us with 932 ads (see Table 2), that is, 83% of all the TV ads in MATVA. A third and final

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filter was applied to eliminate the 147 visually distinct ads for the same products which, although visually distinct, had identical VOs.

The total number of words in MATVA's VOs is 30,448 and the average number of words per ad is 37. Clearly, VOs contain short texts and copywriters need to select the words in them very carefully.

Imperatives: Quantitative results in MATVA and discussion

The identification of imperative clauses in MATVA was achieved by focusing on their central element, that is, the imperative verb. The automatic part of speech annotation only allowed us to identify the base form of verbs. We therefore had to manually identify the imperatives in our corpus of VOs. We found a total of 804 imperative tokens in 424 out of 785 VOs. In other words, imperatives were found in 54.1% of all VOs in MATVA. This empirical finding alone might cast doubts on the central role of imperatives in TV advertising (see Byrne, 1992; Leech, 1966; Myers, 1994). However, as will be shown later, the quantitative comparison with other language registers shows that statistically imperatives are much more common than in other genres.

In the VOs which contain imperatives, just over half of our 424 ads, that is, 222 (52.3%), contain a single imperative, 103 (24.3%) have two imperatives, 55 (13%) have three imperatives and just over 10% have four or more imperatives (see Table 3). Thus, the number of imperatives per ad gradually decreases in proportion to their frequency.

The presence of more than one imperative in the short VO texts, practically half of all instances (47.7%), deserves some attention. The reason for multiple imperatives is mainly due to the presence of two types of imperatives. The first is found in demonstrations on how to use the product, for example, *Just cut the jumbo block to size and simply add water* (JMLDoktorPower). They are cases of instructions which can also be found in genres such as recipes. The second main type offers potential customers different ways to contact the companies being advertised, as in *Call 08009166100 or visit cruisethomascook.com* (Thomas Cook).

Let us focus now on the frequency of imperatives by comparing VOs with other registers. Hyland (2002: 222) concludes that imperatives are the most frequent among all possible directives in academic disciplines, but that only a dozen verbs occur more than once or twice and just 10 items make up 75% of all cases. In addition, Ren (2011: 744) notes that imperatives are pervasive 'in netvertising', although no quantification is supplied. The corpus-based *Longman Grammar of Spoken and Written English* (Biber et al., 1999: 409) shows that imperative clauses are far more common in conversation than in the expository registers, and remark (p. 1045) that:

Table 3. Number of imperatives per ad.

Imperatives per ad	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	Total
Number of ads	222	103	55	25	9	7	1	1	1	424
% of ads	52.4	24.3	13	5.9	2.1	1.7	0.2	0.2	0.2	100%
Total imperatives	222	206	165	100	45	42	7	8	9	804

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Table 4. Most frequent imperatives.

Verb	Tokens	Verb	Tokens
call	94	(don't) miss	12
visit	44	see	12
get (obtain)	32/52	pop (into)	11/13
save	22	come	11
go (online)	20/35	be	10
try	19	feel	9
join	15	Argos	9
love	13	start	9
take (lay hold of)	12/19	let	6/16
party	12	make	5/13

> [. . .] questions and imperatives, the sentence types that typically elicit a response, are more frequent in conversation than in written language. Questions are three to four times more common (. . .) and imperatives are more than five times as common (. . .) in conversation as in any of the other registers.

To compare our frequencies with those offered by Biber et al. (1999), we have normalized the total number of words in the ads with VOs in MATVA to a million words. MATVA yields over 31,000 occurrences per million words. Thus, the presence of imperative clauses in VOs in MATVA is far greater than in conversation, which is around 10,000 occurrences per million words (see Biber et al., 1999: 221). Consequently, the number of imperatives in VOs appears to be higher than in any other genre analysed in Biber et al. (1999). This could contribute to the perception that many have of imperatives as central elements in this kind of discourse (Byrne, 1992; Leech, 1966; Myers, 1994).

The discourse function of imperatives in MATVA

One of our main goals was to offer a discourse classification of imperatives by looking at their meanings and function in the context of the surrounding discourse. To do this we need to go beyond a simple word list which merely identifies the same word forms. Thus we ran *AntConc*'s (Anthony, 2007) concordancing tool which allowed us to determine the meanings of imperatives through the analysis of each verb's co-text. For instance, a verb as common as 'get' has a large number of potential meanings; however, it is only by looking at its collocates in the co-text that its meaning can be pinpointed. Following this procedure, we found that out of 52 instances of 'get', no fewer than 32 (61.5%), can be paraphrased as 'obtain'. Table 4 shows the 20 most common imperative verbs.[2]

There is no doubt that the imperatives 'call', 'visit', 'get', 'save', 'go' or 'try', which are found in a large number of VOs, should be counted as central members of a lexico-semantic inventory in TV advertising. However, as we will see, the total number of verb types in MATVA is far larger and shows that, besides the more conventional lexico-semantic choices shown in Table 4, there is a high degree of lexical open-endedness in advertising.

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Table 5. Discourse functions of imperatives in MATVA.

Function group	Tokens per group	% of tokens total	Types per group	% of types total
Attention focusers	258	32	75	33.5
Contact	228	28.5	20	8.9
Acquisition	138	17.1	33	14.8
Experiencers	137	17	74	33
Others	43	5.4	22	9.8
Total	804	100	224	100

One of our main objectives was to go beyond offering a list of the most frequent imperatives and to classify all the imperatives into groups based on their function in context to provide us with a view of how imperatives are used in VOs. We followed Leech (1966: 100–111), who was the first to attempt such a classification. He identified three major groups in TV ads:

1. Acquisition of the product: *get*, *buy*, *ask for*.
2. Consumption of product: *try*, *use*, *enjoy*.
3. Appeals for notice: *look*, *see*, *watch*, *remember*.

We found it impossible to adhere to Leech's (1966: 110) classification due to the presence of several new imperatives that reflect the technological and social changes which have taken place since his study. Our classification includes five groups: three of these, 'Acquisition', 'Experiencers' and 'Attention Focusers', roughly correspond to the groups above. Unlike Leech (1966: 110), who only mentions 'especially frequent' imperatives, we offer a quantitative description of all the imperatives in MATVA. Table 5 provides the number of tokens and types in each of our five groups and the percentage of each group vis-a-vis the total number of imperatives.

The group of 'Attention focusers' boasts the largest number of imperative tokens in MATVA, 32%. It is made up of 75 verbs, that is, 33.5% of all imperative verb types. In this set we have included those verbs which Leech (1966: 111) grouped under 'Appeals for notice', for example, verbs such as 'look', 'see', 'watch', etc. He noted that such imperatives attempt to focus the attention of viewers on what is happening – often in ads of the demonstration type. These verbs are actually quite infrequent in MATVA. However, there are many more imperatives which are used figuratively to draw the viewer's attention to the product – hence the label 'Attention focusers'. Examples of these imperatives can be seen in: *Value your sleep!* (Dreams), *Spend more time with our little ones* (KFC), *Crave those crazy squares* (Nestlé cereals). As we can see, they often involve emotional appeals. This group provides evidence in favour of Lakoff's (1982: 33) view of persuasive genres largely focusing on feelings rather than rational thought.

While the 'Contact Group' has the second largest number of imperatives tokens (28.5%), it has a small number of verb types, making up only 8.9% of the whole corpus. Just three verbs 'call', 'visit' and 'go (online)' make up just under 70% of all contact tokens. Their function is to encourage viewers to contact retail stores or companies or

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visit their websites. Contact verbs are not mentioned at all by Leech (1966). Obviously, verbs that refer to online shopping could only appear in ads produced since the advent of the internet, circa 1990. Asking viewers to contact a firm by phone is also absent in Leech (1996), simply because making phone calls was much more expensive and therefore infrequent 50 years ago.

The 'Acquisition of Product or Service' group is the third in terms of size. It contains 17.1% of all tokens and 14.8% of all imperative verb types. It is also one of the three groups mentioned by Leech (1966) and contains imperatives like 'bag', 'get', 'join'. We included this last verb as it refers to connecting to online services, which is tantamount to acquiring a product or service. In terms of frequency, a verb like 'get' is particularly favoured by advertisers within the group, since it highlights all the advantages of 'obtaining the product', while avoiding the unpleasantness of having to refer to a money transaction, which is part of the meaning of 'buy' (Brierley, 2000: 168, cited in Barron, 2012: 208). This might explain why we have found only seven examples of the verb 'buy' with a directive function.

The group of 'Experiencers' is quite similar in size to the 'Acquisition group' in terms of tokens: 17%. However, it contains a larger number of different types: 33% in relation to the whole corpus. The token/type ratio of this group shows the highest degree of lexical open-endedness or creativity in MATVA. We contend that this is because of the wide variety of ways a product or service can be used, manipulated or enjoyed. Together with 'Attention focusers', these two groups contain two-thirds of all verb types in the corpus. The imperatives in the 'Experiencers' group refer to actions that presuppose the acquisition of the product. Customers are invited to experience the advertised product or service often vicariously through the actions of actors in demonstrations of the product. 'Experiencers' subsumes Leech's (1966: 111) 'Consumption of Product' group which includes such items as 'enjoy', 'try' and 'use'. Another large subgroup of 'Experiencers' takes the form of instructions on how to use the product or service, such as the following three: *Just shake 3 times, foam it, work it all over from root to tip* (Nice 'n Easy).

The 'Others' group is quite heterogeneous, and represents less than 10% of all imperative verbs. It features imperatives such as 'pledge', 'give', etc., which do not fall into any of the above categories. One of the reasons is that most of them are found in the 26 non-commercial TV ads. Pragmatically, they do not represent the core 'friendly advice' type seen in commercial ads, but rather the 'request' or 'plea' kind of imperative found in public service ads and charity ads. The 'Others' group also contains a small set of imperatives made up of the name of the product or service being advertised such as *Learn Direct* or *Go Compare*.

The pragmatic and discourse features of imperative clauses in MATVA

Two pragmatic factors which have been extensively discussed in connection with imperatives is the cost or benefit of the act to either speaker or addressee (Takahashi, 2011: 3). We contend that the frequency of imperatives and the fact that they are hardly ever accompanied by politeness strategies in TV ads derives from this cost/benefit dichotomy.

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Politeness markers such as 'please', and others such as hedges, are quite common in requests among friends and in service encounters. This is not the case with TV commercials. Byrne (1992: 67) observes that the imperative clauses in advertising copy would have to 'be put in a much more polite fashion' in ordinary conversation. According to Leech (1966: 79), the paucity of explicit politeness markers accompanying imperatives in TV ads is because we are accustomed to unmitigated imperatives in 'public communication' such as the kind found on road signs, on public transport, etc.

Myers (1994: 47) points out an even more compelling reason for the absence of politeness features in TV ads, namely that imperatives are presented as a benefit to the addressee (see also Barron, 2012: 150). Downing and Locke (2006: 206) agree that '[t]he more the action is likely to benefit the addressee, the more socially acceptable an imperative will be'. Thus, the imperatives in TV ads are actually more akin to advice, suggestions or recommendations than orders or commands (see Condoravdi and Lauer, 2012: 38; Schmidt et al., 1995: 287–288). Let us consider this example from MATVA, where the use of a politeness marker such as 'please' to accompany the two 'save' imperatives would be incongruous as the two instances of this verb potentially benefit the addressee:

> Most UK homes don't have the recommended amount of insulation. By properly insulating your home you could save up to £180 a year on heating bills. Save money, save energy.

Quirk et al. (1985: 571) remark that 'unlike the other courtesy subjuncts, *please* is generally confined to sentences constituting a request or containing a reported one'. The examples above constitute 'friendly advice'. In general, politeness markers that mitigate face-threats are quantitatively low in MATVA. For instance, 'please' only accompanies imperatives in 13 cases – all but one of them coming from charity ads like the one represented by this fragment:

> Please pledge just two pounds a month to the NSPCC and be there for children in desperate need. Please open your eyes and your heart.

The small group of charity ads differs from the much more frequent commercial ads in MATVA because they are illocutionary acts of begging, not advice. Begging fits into Huddleston's (2002: 930) description of the category of requests, pleas and entreaties.

Hedging is also often cited as a major mitigating strategy used to soften face threats. The adverbs 'just' and 'simply' are commonly cited as examples of prototypical hedges and as such generally act as deference-giving negative politeness strategies (Brown and Levinson, 1987 [1978]: 178). However, in our corpus these adverbs are infrequently used; the adverb 'simply' is found in 14 clauses, and 'just' in 17. Let us examine two representative examples of 'simply' in MATVA:

> Simply place your order online and pick it up when you next pop in (Tesco)
>
> Simply register online (Pringles)

In the case of 'just', added to its scarcity is the fact that it does not always function as a softener. In the following two examples it is employed to 'reinforce the truth value

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of the proposition' and intensify the truth of the assertion (Fuertes-Olivera et al., 2001: 1300):

> Just look at the difference. Fresh, tasty, delicious (JML Keep Fresh Bags)
>
> Just ask 89% of glamour readers who recommend (Special K)

The adverbs 'today' and 'now' co-occur with imperatives 75 and 21 times, respectively. Unlike 'simply' and 'just', they express urgency and would theoretically increase imposition. However, the clauses and sentences in which they appear generally contain elements which soften the threat somewhat. In the first example the phone call is free, the second offers *free parking* and *free spending money*, and the third suggests that you may discover mysterious personality features.

> Call Computeach free now on 0800657657. (Computeach)
>
> Book now for free parking and free spending money. (Thomas Cook)
>
> Take new match.com's personality test today and discover the kind of person you're meant to be with. (Match.com)

Finally, we will focus on negative imperatives which are infrequent according to Leech (1966: 30). He reasons that this is because the tone of a TV ad should be 'positive' and avoid 'discouraging negatives' and 'prohibitive warnings' (Leech, 1966: 111). In MATVA negative imperatives number only 30 out of a total of 804 imperatives, that is, 3.73%. This result is about the same as that reported by Leech (1966: 111), 3.85%. Our interpretation of the inclusion of negative imperatives differs from Leech's (p.111). We contend that they come across as an altruistic act on the part of the advertiser. In 12 cases the negative imperative involves 'miss' (see Table 4) as in:

> Don't miss the thousands of bargains in the summer meltdown (Derry & Homemaker)

In this example the negative directive 'don't miss' is equivalent to affirmative 'go', or 'visit', but has a lower sense of obligation in a scenario which is presented as highly beneficial for the viewer, no less than the possibility of acquiring *thousands of bargains*.

Negative imperatives used with other verbs in MATVA often participate in parallel problem–solution utterances. Typically, the initial negative imperative warns against doing something, but is immediately followed by a second positive imperative clause that offers a solution to the potential problem the viewer is presented with in the first clause:

> Don't break up with your hair, keep it looking full and thick (H&S)
>
> Don't change your lifestyle, change your supermarket (Aldi)
>
> Don't just wear it, live it! (Matalan)
>
> Don't just change a colour, change a mood (Dulux)

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Contrary to what Leech (1966: 111) seems to suggest, negative imperatives can be part of very upbeat advertising copy such as the aforementioned examples.

Conclusions

Takahashi (2012: 2) laments the dearth of quantitative, usage-based research in the area of imperatives. One of our aims in this article has been to contribute to this task by analysing the frequency, meaning and function of imperative clauses in TV advertising. We have done this through the empirical analysis of a large number of transcribed VOs from the MATVA corpus of British TV ads.

From a quantitative viewpoint our findings have brought to light several interesting facts about imperatives in VOs in British TV ads. Leech (1966: 30) talks about the 'extreme frequency of imperatives' in VOs. However, we have shown that not all ads feature VOs – 83% in our corpus. Furthermore, of these just over half contain imperatives – 54%. That means that imperatives are heard in just 37% of our corpus of non-duplicate ads as a whole. In spite of all this, in terms of frequency, Leech (1966) is right if we compare imperatives in VOs with other genres. Imperatives are much more common in our corpus than in many other types of discourse such as conversation which, according to Biber et al. (1999: 221), contains the largest number of this type of construction in the genres they analysed. This fact would explain why imperatives are perceived as very frequent in TV ads.

Imperatives in our corpus are practically the only directives used in contrast with Hyland's (2002) academic corpus, where numerous modal verbs and predicative adjectives were identified. The only two directives which are not expressed through imperatives in our corpus are *you should go to DFS* and *you must be sure to Go Compare*. The results from MATVA also differ from Hyland's (2002: 222) research into academic genres. In his corpus, verbs such as 'see', 'note' and 'consider' had, by far, the highest frequency, while in ours, contact verbs were by far the most numerous.

We have also been able to give a comprehensive overview of the different groups that imperatives belong to with regard to discourse function. The lack of quantitative information in Leech (1966) does not allow us to compare our data with his, while in other research (Ohata, 2004; O'Neill and Casanovas-Catalá, 1997; Schmidt et al., 1995) no information on the discourse function of imperatives is offered. We have shown that 'Acquisition' verbs, including the most prototypical of them all – 'buy', are far from being the most common imperatives, while a new group, 'Contact', has a small number of very frequent tokens. In fact, the most frequent tokens of all are the contact verbs 'call' and visit'. All the members of the other main groups have been identified, not just the most salient members as in Leech (1966).

According to Brown and Levinson (1987 [1978]: 76), the weightiness of a face-threatening act depends on the social distance between the addresser and the addressee, the relative power between the two and how imposing the imperative, in this case, is judged to be in a particular culture. As far as the first two parameters are concerned, viewers of TV ads have almost no compulsion to comply with imperatives, first because the addressers are relatively anonymous and second because they do not have the power to compel the viewer to buy a product or service. This leaves the level of imposition of

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the imperatives themselves. Although many of the imperatives in TV ads request viewers to carry out what Hyland (2002: 225) calls 'real-world' actions – especially those in the 'Contact' and 'Experiencers' groups – our contention is that these requests are couched as disinterested advice in some cases or useful instructions in others. Even so, care is taken to reduce imposition, which would explain the infrequency of the imperative 'buy', with its unfortunate connotations of parting with one's money and the fact that it is replaced by the less imposing 'get'.

From a politeness perspective, the addresser's powerlessness does not explain the scarcity of overt politeness formulae such as 'please' or the paucity of adverbial hedges in our corpus of nearly 800 VOs. It is almost an axiom that when addressers lack the power to impose their will, they would be expected to use more politeness markers to achieve their ends than equals would. Just the opposite happens in TV-ad discourse. A possible explanation is that there is a balance between deferring to the addressee and insisting on the merits of a particular product. Too much deference might suggest that the product is not as good as it should be (Pennock-Speck and del Saz-Rubio, 2013: 51). Furthermore, copywriters know that viewers do not expect or indeed want the same politeness conventions from an anonymous VO as they would from a conversational partner. In TV ads, courteous prolixity of the kind we find in conversation – 'if you don't mind, could you please call as soon as possible' – might even be considered sarcastic. Another reason for the conciseness that imperatives bring is that there is really no time for verbosity in a 10- or 20-second commercial packed with product information.

We have attempted to place our research within a wider chronological perspective. This was one of the reasons for the numerous comparisons with Leech's seminal publication (1966). It would have been interesting to establish whether the number of VOs has increased since the 1960s or otherwise, and likewise with regard to the imperatives within them. Unfortunately, Leech (1966) does not mention how many ads contain VOs in his study and how many do not. Nor does he supply quantitative information on imperatives in his corpus. It is therefore impossible to ascertain whether the presence of VOs and imperatives is greater now than it was. Our research does, however, provide the basis for further studies in this direction.

We are aware that TV ads have probably changed somewhat since Leech's study (1966). According to Yeshin (2006: 3), TV marketing has evolved from the '1950s hard- and straight-selling approach'. This would mean that imperatives, the epitome of hard-sell, would be less frequent now than they were. However, he offers no evidence at all. Yeshin (p. 67) also claims that '[t]he emphasis is less on the words being used than the impact of the visual treatments employed'. This would obviously affect the frequency of imperatives along with verbal discourse in general in today's TV ads. However, to date, no research has offered concrete proof for a greater preponderance of the visual semiotic mode. Once again, our results, in this case regarding the percentage of ads featuring VOs, could be compared with those of future studies to gauge whether this tendency actually has some basis in fact.

To sum up, our study offers the most comprehensive quantitative and qualitative analyses of imperatives in VOs in British TV ads to date and provides a solid basis for future studies into imperatives in TV ads and other genres. It also supplies important

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quantitative data on VOs that might shed light on changes in communicative strategies within the TV-ad genre.

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Notes

1. In a contribution to *Forbes*, Robert Hof highlights that in spite of the rise in internet advertising, more money is currently being spent on TV advertising: http://www.forbes.com/sites/roberthof/2011/08/26/online-ad-spend-to-overtake-tv/ (accessed February 2013).
2. Note that in the cells with one number in the tokens columns, the imperative has a single meaning; in those cells with two numbers separated by a slash, the first number refers to the most common meaning and the second to the total number of tokens.

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